ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

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Mental Health and Stress: Coping Skills That Actually Help

Understand stress, spot warning signs and know when to ask for help

HEALTH & WELLBEING

Health & Wellbeing

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

First year brings new academic pressure, financial strain and social change at once. This pack explains the stress response, distinguishes normal pressure from warning signs, teaches practical coping skills and sets out how and where to seek help.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Explain the stress response and differentiate acute from chronic stress.
- Recognise warning signs that need professional support.
- Apply evidence-based coping strategies for study and daily life.
- Know where to seek help on and off campus.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

What stress is doing

Stress is a physiological response to demand. It is useful in short bursts and harmful when unrelieved.

- Acute stress sharpens attention briefly; chronic stress impairs memory, sleep and immunity.
- Common signs: persistent worry, irritability, poor concentration, changes in sleep and appetite.
- Burnout combines exhaustion, cynicism and reduced effectiveness.
- Some stress is normal; being unable to function is not a character flaw.
- Substance use may feel like relief but worsens anxiety and sleep.
- Naming what you feel reduces its intensity and helps you act.

Coping that works

Choose strategies that address the cause and regulate the body.

- Break overwhelming work into the next single action.
- Use slow breathing for two minutes to reduce acute arousal.
- Protect sleep, meals and movement even during exams.
- Schedule worry time rather than worrying all day.
- Talk to one trusted person weekly.
- Reduce comparison with social media; other people's highlights are edited.

> **When to seek help**
> Seek professional support if low mood lasts more than two weeks, if you cannot attend classes, or if you have thoughts of harming yourself. This is a medical issue, not weakness.

Getting support

Help exists, and using it early makes a difference.

- Campus counselling unit or guidance office.
- University health centre for assessment and referral.
- A trusted lecturer, level adviser or chaplain.
- National mental-health helplines and teaching-hospital services.
- A trusted friend or family member who can accompany you.
- In an emergency, go to the nearest hospital or call emergency services.

Stress is a response, not a weakness

Stress is the body's response to a demand it perceives as exceeding its resources. In short bursts it is useful: it sharpens attention before an examination. It becomes harmful when it is chronic, when the demand never lifts and the body never returns to baseline. That is when sleep, appetite, concentration and immunity begin to suffer.

University creates specific stressors: financial pressure, academic workload, distance from family, crowded accommodation, uncertain outcomes and social comparison. Naming the specific stressor matters, because "I am stressed" cannot be acted on while "I cannot sleep because I am worried about fees" can.

Mental health is not the absence of difficulty. It is the capacity to function, to feel, and to seek help when functioning is impaired. Everyone has bad weeks; the question is whether the bad weeks are becoming the pattern.

What helps, in order of evidence

The foundations are unglamorous and effective: sleep on a regular schedule, eat regularly, move your body most days, and reduce alcohol and stimulants. None of these is a cure, and all of them make everything else easier.

Practical stress management: break tasks into next actions, write worries down rather than rehearsing them, set a boundary on rumination by scheduling a short worry period, and use breathing or paced exercise to settle the physical response. Social contact is not optional - isolation amplifies almost every symptom.

Cognitive approaches help by noticing and testing thoughts rather than obeying them: "I will fail everything" is a prediction, not a fact, and it can be checked against what has actually happened. This is the core of what counselling teaches, and it is learnable.

> **Sleep is treatment**
> Regular sleep and wake times, no screens in bed, and no caffeine after midday will improve mood and concentration faster than most other changes.

When to seek help, and how

Seek help when symptoms last more than two weeks, when they interfere with attendance or study, when sleep or appetite are significantly changed, or when you have thoughts of harming yourself. Any of these is sufficient - you do not need to be at breaking point.

Sources: the university counselling service, the health centre, your religious community, a trusted lecturer, and helplines. If you are in immediate danger, go to the health centre or a hospital, and tell someone physically near you.

Supporting a friend: ask directly and calmly, listen without rushing to advice, take statements about self-harm seriously, and help them make contact with a service. Do not promise secrecy about a risk to life. Looking after yourself while supporting someone is not selfishness; it is what makes the support sustainable.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Breaking a stress spiral

You cannot sleep because of an exam in five days and a fee deadline.

1. Write down the two stressors separately; they need different actions.
2. For the exam: list the topics and pick the two weakest to start with.
3. For the fees: identify one person or office to speak to and one question to ask.
4. Set a time tomorrow to do each first action.
5. Write the worries on paper and put them away until that time.
6. Fix a wake time and stop studying one hour before bed.

> **What to carry forward**
> One action per stressor, scheduled. Rumination is not planning.

2. Supporting a friend who is struggling

A friend has stopped attending and says there is no point.

1. Ask directly: "how are you actually doing?" and wait.
2. Listen without correcting or minimising.
3. Ask whether they have thoughts of harming themselves.
4. If yes, do not leave them alone and help them contact the health centre or a helpline.
5. Offer something concrete: accompany them to the appointment, share notes.
6. Check in again in a few days - sustained contact matters more than one conversation.

> **What to carry forward**
> Direct questions do not plant the idea; they open the door.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Distinguish acute from chronic stress and explain why the distinction matters.

15 marks

1. Acute: short-lived response to a specific demand; can improve performance.
2. Chronic: sustained demand without recovery; impairs sleep, immunity, mood, cognition.
3. The distinction determines the intervention: recovery versus removing the stressor.

Q2. List the signs that a student should seek professional help.

10 marks

1. Symptoms lasting more than two weeks.
2. Functional impairment in study or attendance.
3. Major changes in sleep or appetite.
4. Any thoughts of self-harm.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Stressor. A demand perceived as exceeding available resources.

Acute stress. A short-term response to a specific demand.

Chronic stress. Sustained stress without adequate recovery.

Rumination. Repetitive thinking about a problem without progressing towards action.

Cognitive restructuring. Testing and revising unhelpful thoughts.

Burnout. Exhaustion from prolonged unmanaged demand.

Counselling. Confidential talking therapy with a trained professional.

Stigma. Social disapproval that discourages help-seeking.

Sleep hygiene. Habits that support regular, sufficient sleep.

Safety plan. A pre-agreed set of steps for a crisis, including contacts.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Notice

Patterns.

- Log sleep, mood and study hours for seven days.
- Name the top two stressors.
- Set a fixed wake time.

Week 2 - Act

First steps.

- Take one action on each stressor.
- Schedule one social contact.
- Reduce caffeine after midday.

Week 3 - Skills

Thinking.

- Write one worry and test it against evidence.
- Practise a breathing exercise daily.
- Use a scheduled worry period.

Week 4 - Support

Help.

- Identify the counselling contact.
- Have one honest conversation.
- Write a personal safety plan.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Your institution's counselling and health service information.
- A self-help guide based on cognitive behavioural principles.
- A guide to supporting a friend in distress.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Distinguish acute from chronic stress.

Answer: Acute stress is short-lived and can improve performance. Chronic stress persists, exhausting resources and impairing health and cognition.

2. Name three warning signs that warrant professional support.

Answer: Persistent low mood for over two weeks, inability to function academically, and thoughts of self-harm.

3. Why is sleep protective for mental health?

Answer: Sleep supports emotional regulation, memory consolidation and stress-hormone balance.

4. Give one practical way to reduce overwhelm.

Answer: Identify the next single action and do only that, rather than planning the entire semester at once.

5. What should you do if a friend discloses thoughts of self-harm?

Answer: Take it seriously, stay with them, encourage immediate professional help and accompany them to a health facility or call emergency services.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write your three main stressors this semester.
- [ ] Learn and practise a two-minute breathing exercise.
- [ ] Set a consistent sleep and wake time for two weeks.
- [ ] Identify one trusted person you can talk to weekly.
- [ ] Save the campus counselling and health-centre contacts.
- [ ] Schedule one recovery activity each week.
- [ ] Check in on a coursemate who seems withdrawn.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date: